

PATRICIA MALAY

THE CAREER OPTIONS AUDIT

How dependent is your career on
one company, one title or one
path saying yes?

A 10-minute assessment for experienced
women who want more choices for what
comes next.

Print it, or type into it on screen.

I used to think career success was something someone else gave you.

The promotion.

The title.

The acclaim.

You worked hard. Proved yourself. Took on more responsibility.

And eventually, someone decided you were ready for the next thing.

For most of my career, I was good at that game.

Then I went through cancer.

It changed my relationship with time.

I remember thinking:

I don't want to wait around for someone else to tell me what I'm worth. How high I can climb. Or where I can go next.

Because I realised something about the career I'd built.

When your entire career is built around a ladder, someone else is always deciding whether you get to take the next step.

I didn't suddenly decide I needed to become an entrepreneur.

I wanted something much simpler.

I wanted choices.

So I started creating them.

A coaching business.

Then one startup.

Then another.

None of it came from some grand master plan.

I simply stopped wanting my future to depend on one person, one company or one career path saying yes.

And that changed the way I think about career success.

I don't just want a career that can go up.

I want a career that gives me somewhere else to go.

That's what this short audit will help you start thinking about.

How dependent is your career on one path?

Check every statement that's currently true for you.

- | | |
|---|---|
| ☐ Most of my professional income comes from one employer. | ☐ Most of my professional reputation is connected to my current title or company. |
| ☐ My strongest professional relationships are people I know through my current organisation. | ☐ Most people outside my company don't really know what I'm good at. |
| ☐ I haven't built a professional reputation around anything beyond my current role. | ☐ If I left tomorrow, I'm not sure which parts of my expertise I could turn into something else. |
| ☐ I rarely speak to people outside my immediate professional circle about what I'm interested in next. | ☐ I haven't seriously considered advisory, board, consulting, teaching, speaking, investing or other ways my experience could be useful. |
| ☐ My CV explains my career history, but I haven't articulated the value that connects it all. | ☐ If my role disappeared unexpectedly, I would immediately need another similar job. |
| ☐ I have ideas about what I'd like to do "one day," but I'm not actively testing any of them. | ☐ I'm waiting for more certainty before I explore anything outside my current path. |

What did you notice?

Don't worry about the number of boxes you checked. This isn't a test you pass or fail. Instead, ask yourself:

How much of what I've built belongs to me, and how much depends on the position I'm currently in?

Your answer gives you a starting point.

What actually travels with you?

When you leave an organisation, your title may not travel with you. But you don't leave empty-handed.

1 Your expertise

What do you know how to do unusually well?

My answer

3 Your judgment

What kinds of difficult decisions do people trust you to make?

My answer

5 Your point of view

What has experience taught you that you now see differently from someone earlier in their career?

My answer

Over the course of your career, you've accumulated professional assets. The question is whether you've identified them and made them portable.

2 Your evidence

What have you changed, built, solved, grown, protected or led?

One example

4 Your relationships

Who knows your work well enough to recommend you? Three people:

6 Your reputation

What do people consistently come to you for?

My answer

These are career assets.

They can create value inside your current role, but they don't have to stay there. The more clearly you can articulate them, the easier it becomes to see what else they could make possible.

Start building your career web

Your next chapter doesn't have to be a choice between *Stay where I am* or *Leave and start again*. There are many ways to use the experience you've already earned.

Your current role can remain part of your career. The goal is to start seeing what else could sit alongside it or grow from it.

Leadership

- ☐ A bigger role
- ☐ A different organisation
- ☐ A regional or global remit
- ☐ A new sector

Governance

- ☐ Board roles
- ☐ Committee positions
- ☐ Trustee roles
- ☐ Industry bodies

Advisory

- ☐ Advisory positions
- ☐ Consulting
- ☐ Fractional leadership
- ☐ Mentoring or coaching

Intellectual authority

- ☐ Speaking
- ☐ Writing
- ☐ Teaching
- ☐ Research
- ☐ Media commentary

Enterprise

- ☐ A specialist practice
- ☐ A product or service
- ☐ A startup
- ☐ A partnership
- ☐ Investing

Community and influence

- ☐ Professional associations
- ☐ Private networks
- ☐ Industry initiatives
- ☐ Nonprofit leadership

Something else

Now circle or mark the two or three options that make you curious.

Not the ones you think you should want. Not the ones that sound most impressive. Choose the ones you genuinely want to understand better.

You're not choosing a new career today. You're identifying possible directions your existing career could grow into.

Which option is worth exploring?

Choose one possibility from the previous page. Now test it.

The option I want to explore _____

DESIRE

Do I actually want this?

Not: Would it look impressive? Would I enjoy some part of actually doing it?

☐ Yes ☐ Maybe ☐ No

ACCESS

Do I know anyone connected to this world?

☐ Yes ☐ Not yet

If yes, who? _____

EXPERIMENT

Could I test this without making a major career decision?

☐ Yes ☐ Not sure

FIT

Does this use something I've already earned?

Think about your experience, credibility, relationships, knowledge and judgment.

☐ Strong fit ☐ Some fit ☐ Little fit

EVIDENCE

Can I point to evidence that I could contribute here?

☐ Yes ☐ Some ☐ Not yet

What evidence do I already have? _____

Your best next option doesn't need to be certain. It needs to be testable.

Run one small career experiment

You don't need to make a five-year plan before you do anything. Run a small experiment instead.

If you're curious about board work

Speak with two people currently serving on boards and ask how they made the transition and what boards actually look for.

If you're curious about speaking

Develop one topic based on something your experience has taught you. Test it in a small professional setting.

If you're curious about another sector

Speak with two senior people already working in it before you start applying for roles.

Choose something that helps you learn whether this option deserves more of your time.

If you're curious about advisory work

Identify three problems people already seek your advice on. Speak with people in your network about where that expertise could be useful.

If you're curious about consulting

Have three conversations with people who might buy or refer the type of expertise you could offer. Listen for the problems they would actually pay to solve.

If you're curious about writing or thought leadership

Choose one subject where you have genuine experience and publish one useful point of view. Pay attention to the conversations it creates.

If you're curious about something else

Design the smallest action that would give you real information about it.

My 30-day career experiment

THE OPTION I'M EXPLORING

IN THE NEXT 30 DAYS, I WILL

I WILL SPEAK TO

WHAT I WANT TO LEARN IS

AT THE END OF 30 DAYS, I WILL DECIDE

☐ Explore further ☐ Change direction ☐ Stop

Stopping is a valid result.

The purpose of an experiment isn't to prove that every idea should become part of your career. It's to replace assumption with information.

Your career doesn't need one answer

For years, I thought career progress meant knowing which rung I wanted next.

I don't think about it that way anymore.

You can have a serious job and build something alongside it.

You can pursue promotion and explore board work.

You can be an executive and develop a point of view that belongs to you, not only to your employer.

You can advise.

Teach.

Invest.

Build.

Write.

Speak.

Or simply start having conversations that expand your sense of what's possible.

You don't have to do all of those things. And you certainly don't have to leave a successful career to prove that you have options.

The point is to start building a professional life where your future doesn't depend entirely on one person, one organisation or one decision.

ONE QUESTION TO TAKE WITH YOU

If my current path stopped being available tomorrow, what else have I built that could carry me forward?

If your answer today is "not enough," you don't need to overhaul your life.

Start smaller. One option. One conversation. One experiment. And see where it takes you.

Build the authority that gives you options

Creating career options starts with understanding what you have that can travel.

Your experience.

Your evidence.

Your judgment.

Your point of view.

Your relationships.

Your reputation.

And clear language for the contribution you want to make next.

That's the work I help experienced women do.



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